



THE INSTITUTE OF
MASTERS
of WINE

Practical Report

2024 Stage 2 MW Exam

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Practical Exam Chair Report, Peter Marks MW

This year's practical exam saw 17 out of 140 candidates successfully pass, and congratulations to this group! This represents a pass rate of 12.1%, just slightly below the pass rates of 2023 (13.5%) and 2022 (13.3%) but certainly far above the post-Covid exam of 2021 when only 8% achieved a pass. Of the 17 passes, 8 earned a pass prior to my moderation and an additional 9 passed after moderation. During moderation, I am not trying to award a certain number or a percentage of passes; instead, I look for candidates who can demonstrate mastery across all aspects of the exam – tasting ability, excellent communication skills using correct theory knowledge, logic and deductive reasoning, and the ability to judge quality.

One positive aspect of the exam was the success rate for paper 1 (55.5% average mark) versus paper 2 (55.1%) and paper 3 (53.4%). This seems to indicate that candidates are heeding our advice to come into the exam with better time discipline as fewer questions were left unanswered. Another bright spot was the fine results from candidates sitting the exam for the first time. This group showed a 13.2% pass rate, which is slightly better than the other candidates who have sat previously (11.8%). This shows the practical exam is possible to pass if you put in the work, and surely a testament to the great efforts of the education team over the past several years.

What was disappointing was the large number of overall "Ds" and "Fs" in this year's exam. More than one-third of the candidates earned one of these failing grades, which indicates they were not ready to sit the exam and much more work is necessary for them to be successful in the future. Plus, many of these individuals earned an average mark of "F" which means they will lose an exam attempt in the future. We cannot emphasize enough the importance of being properly prepared to sit the exam or

being honest with yourself if you are not and using your regulation deferral wisely (see the student guide for more detail on deferral regulations).

You will hear Master of Wine examiners say that the MW practical exam is a theory exam with a tasting. This is truer today than ever before. As many wine styles around the world are more alike than different, the practical exam has evolved over the years and today it relies less on “getting the wine right” and focuses more on theoretical aspects such as commercial appeal, winemaking, maturity and vintage. In fact, these latter four types of questions accounted for 42% of all marks across the three practical papers, while identification made up 39% of the marks, and quality represented 19%.

When examiners mark papers, they are encouraged to mark positively, knowing that no one is perfect, and we all make mistakes. We look for good tasting ability (able to correctly identify alcohol, sugar, oak, etc.), the capability to make logical conclusions from the evidence in the glass (even if conclusion is wrong), and the skill to judge quality, maturity and commercial appeal. But what frequently determines whether a borderline candidate achieves an overall pass or not, is their theory knowledge. When I moderate borderline candidates (typically those falling in the C+ or 60% - 64% range across all three papers) it is often the theory knowledge that lets candidates down.

It is hard to feel confident about a borderline candidate when they make obvious theory mistakes. A few examples: Mentioning Marsanne as a permitted variety in white Châteauneuf-du-Pape (P1, wine 12); thinking Sauternes (P3, wines 6 and 7) are fermented at 16°C in stainless steel; and indicating Muscat Beaumes de Venise (P3, wine 11) has 90 g/L residual sugar. In addition, for candidates using computers, the overuse of copying and pasting, especially for winemaking and commercial questions, creates considerable doubt in the mind of the reader.

Please carefully read the paper chair reports as much more detailed analysis is contained therein. They point out the primary areas of success and failures among the different types of questions. If any of the latter corresponds to your weaknesses, then be sure diligently practice these shortcomings to improve in the future. That said, I will comment on three areas that stood out for me – not answering the question, commercial appeal answers and paper 3.

As candidates know, there are only seven types of questions on the practical exam – grape variety, origin, quality, maturity, winemaking, style and commercial appeal. However, these questions can be asked in different ways and that seemed to throw some candidates off their game this year. Paper 2, Q2 asked to suggest an ideal drinking window, which is another way of asking about maturity, but some candidates failed to recognize that or even failed to address that part of the question. Also on paper 2, Q3 asked candidates to discuss climate with respect to quality and style of the wine. Few individuals made reasoned arguments regarding climate. On paper 3, two of the questions asked were about commercial opportunities and *challenges* and many neglected to answer the latter.

Speaking of commercial questions, this is truly an opportunity for candidates to demonstrate their theoretical knowledge. If candidates have studied for theory papers 4 and 5, they should have a good understanding of trends in the wine industry and be able to provide insightful answers instead of the typical, rote responses of selling the wine in fine-dining restaurant, by wine-by-the glass, or to affluent connoisseurs, etc. Candidates should be able to easily garner full marks for commercial responses if they have thought about and studied the types of wines that may show up on the exam *before* they enter the exam room, thereby saving time trying to come up with an answer on the spur of the moment.

During my moderation it became very clear that paper 3 was the make-or-break paper this year. paper 1 had 31 passes, paper 2 had 25 passes, and paper 3 had only 15 passes. It was disappointing to see so many near passes fall short on this last paper. Again, it was lack of theory knowledge that hurt many of these near passes; for example, correctly identifying the icewine but having 13.5% alcohol, or fortifying the Muscat Beaumes de Venise with 99% spirit. Indeed, the last question on paper 3 was where many candidates struggled. Most candidates were able to identify three of the five wines (icewine, Muscat Beaumes de Venise and Vouvray Demi-Sec). Yet many thought the Vin Santo was a Madeira and while they earned some marks for correctly noting the oxidative aging, they failed to recognize the wine's levels of alcohol and residual sugar. The trouble candidates had with paper 3 indicates that they need to study their theory knowledge of these wines and practice tasting wines with different levels of alcohol, sugar, and acidity.

Finally, I would like to thank all the practical examiners this year for their thoughtful exam questions, fine selection of wines, and diligence in marking papers. This is done as a labor of love more than anything else, and nothing would please us more than to see more practical passes in the years to come.

Paper one report 2024: Paper chair, Ulf Sjödin MW

Paper 1 was divided into three questions, each being very different in terms of the skills tested. Q1 was very straightforward, with the three most international grape varieties in two different quality levels. Not surprisingly, this was the easiest part of the exam for most candidates, and the one with the highest pass mark.

Many candidates successfully identified the different levels of quality quite accurately, using the full scale of quality levels from Grand Cru to high-volume entry-level wine. Those who were less successful stayed in the mid field, commenting more on differences in style than quality. There was a 50% pass rate on Q1, so it was the question that saved the day for many candidates. A Master of Wine exam doesn't get more straightforward than this question, so those who struggled with Q1 should probably spend much more time tasting for future exams.

Wine 1 was identified correctly by most candidates, and for wine 2 the examiners could give good marks for many quality regions in Germany, Austria or France. Most candidates also saw the huge difference in quality between wines 3 and 4. The best candidates identified that the character of wine 4 could fit many high volume regions, and good marks were given to any well-argued bulk origin. Many candidates went for the correct origin South Eastern Australia, but we also saw many answers in the style of "the moderate quality leads to a high volume region like South Australia". Candidates should be aware of the differences between these two regions, and the quality differences between them.

Q2 was the difficult part, testing aromatic varieties of very different character. The examiners were aware of the challenges and marked according to that. Most candidates identified the Alsace wine, but many candidates went for Muscat or Pinot Gris instead of Gewurztraminer. The Moschofilero was only identified by a few candidates, but good marks could be gained from other grapes with coloured skin. Sadly, many candidates went straight for Pinot Grigio without proper arguments and lost many marks. On the other hand, some candidates got good pass marks for Pinot Grigio, but with arguments in winemaking and origin that made the choice more plausible.

Q3 was the theory question of this exam. Finding a country with three possible blends that are distinct enough for an MW exam shouldn't have been a big problem. Still, we saw many different approaches where origins were shoehorned into something that didn't always make much sense. Still, most candidates went for France, and the white Pessac was probably the wine that most candidates identified correctly, with the exception of the wine 1 Mosel. Some fantastic answers gave very high marks here.

In Q3, some candidates didn't read the question and placed the wines in different countries. There is no penalty for that, except for the fact that a maximum one wine could get a top score. The Jurançon wine was identified by more candidates than we expected, although more than one candidate thought that Jurançon was in the Jura region. There were also candidates who stopped at "Northern Rhône" or "Southern Rhône" when asked for the origin. This will often yield a zero mark, since it gives examiners the impression that the candidate doesn't know any regions within the Rhône valley. Using Marsanne as an argument for white Châteauneuf-du-Pape could be a reminder for some candidates to refresh the Diploma syllabus.

Some general observations

Quality statements were better than ever, which was encouraging. There are however still many candidates who lost marks on quality by not using the legal quality levels available. If you are in Pessac and think that the wine is great, why not mention that it is a Grand Cru Classé level?

Some otherwise good candidates obviously have very limited knowledge on high volume wines. Using “entry level” with a £15 price tag clearly shows that the candidate has no idea of the price of a bottle of Yellowtail in the supermarkets. On the other hand, there were also candidates who thought that 50 USD was a normal price for a top-quality Premier Cru white Burgundy.

Assessment of the basic structural elements like sugar and acidity were quite often less accurate, and many candidates would have been much better at identifying the origins with a better understanding of the fundamental structural elements. “High acidity” on wines 8 and 9 led some candidates to the wrong regions.

Winemaking answers were variable in quality, and some candidates seemed to use copy/paste for their winemaking answers, using for example cold soak on virtually every wine. Regarding winemaking, there seems to be a limited understanding of how long it takes to get some tannic structure from a grape. Answers were between 1 hour cold soak, to 25 days of maceration during fermentation for the same wine. It is rare to get any tannic structure from white grapes with only a short pre fermentation maceration. Some candidates should try to gather more examples on different winemaking practices.

On the whole, we saw many good answers and there were 31 passes on Paper 1, some of them well above the pass mark.

Paper two report 2024: Paper chair, Peter Mitchell MW

Paper 2 this year contained no unusual varieties and, perhaps with the exception of wine 9, no esoteric origins. It was full of classic examples of well known wines and with less than a third of the marks available for identifying origin, it was designed not so much to stretch the deductive talents of candidates, but to allow the best to demonstrate their ability to taste the elements of the wines and to translate this into discussions about climate, winemaking, maturity quality, and style.

There were many fine papers and a handful of exceptional ones, but also too many who did not fully address the questions asked, missing out on potential marks. I would urge candidates to look carefully at mark allocation before starting writing and plan their time accordingly. Most of those who passed answered parts 1b) and 3c) (worth over a third of the marks) thoughtfully and comprehensively, those who fell short nearly always gave inadequate answers to these two questions.

Question 1

The overwhelming majority of candidates identified the variety correctly as Syrah, however many seemed to struggle with contrasting the styles and consumer appeal. Most candidates had difficulty with origins of some or all of what were classic styles of the variety and the markers often felt that the answers to style and consumer appeal were written based on an erroneous identification rather than by discussing what was in the glass. Many chose not to compare the wines at all and once again this year, too many talked about steakhouses as the answer to commercial appeal.

Question 2

This was the best answered question overall with some highly accomplished answers. Wines 4 and 7 were almost universally identified, with 5 and 6 causing a few more problems with a number of candidates putting wine 5 in Bordeaux and wine 6 in Ribera del Duero. These were classic examples and with the question limiting the number of possible origins, successful candidates really needed to be correct and give good reasoning. Quality was generally well covered, although few were prepared to sing the praises of wine 7 as much as they should have. The question asked for quality in the context of origin and for those who did not refer back to the origin, few marks were available. The vintage and drinking window question exposed the lack of vintage knowledge many have outside of Bordeaux. The marks here were mostly for reasoning and any number of answers showed no knowledge of the characteristics of recent vintages in the classic regions of Italy and Spain.

Question 3

The grape variety was almost universally identified as Pinot Noir and most scored very good marks for this part. The best covered all of the structural elements and referred to each of the wines drawing together a convincing argument with several candidates achieving full marks on this part. The origin part of the question was tackled very poorly, with many candidates putting all 5 wines in the wrong origin. Examiners are aware that getting one wine wrong can lead to a domino effect in a question like this and 4 of the 5 marks available per wine were for reasoning, however, even this was often lacking. Part c was not a question format seen in previous exams and this seems to have thrown some candidates and as a result was the worst answered question on the paper. The best answers logically described the style and quality and then tied these to how climate and winemaking would have played a part in this. Too many

concentrated on just one thing, for example winemaking, not mentioning climate or what the style and quality of the wine were. Many candidates seemed obsessed by whole bunch and found evidence of it in every wine, whilst missing the oak usage present.

Paper three report 2024: Paper chair, Lisa Perrotti-Brown MW

This year's Paper 3 exam was designed to test tasting ability across a broad range of regions, styles, and winemaking practices. Successful performances came from those who not only had comprehensive experience describing and evaluating less-common wines but also had the technical knowledge to identify key winemaking techniques and lock in on correct alcohol and sweetness levels. A well-considered strategy (e.g., the order in which to taste the wines) and time management were critical for this paper.

Question 1

Non-Champagne sparkling wine is a category of increasing popularity and importance in markets around the world, but selling these wines is not without its challenges. The first part of question 1 aimed to test candidates' abilities to evaluate two such sparkling wines, highlighting their unique winemaking and style attributes. This first half of the question was generally well-answered. However, more points were allocated to the second half of the question, which compared and contrasted the commercial opportunities and challenges for these wines. This latter part seemed to throw a lot of candidates off, resulting in many vague and poorly considered responses that failed to link what was in the glass to their points being raised. Passes were achieved by those who wove the perceived quality and style into issues such as regional market demand for these styles, price consciousness, and niche opportunities.

Question 2

Question 2 should have been straightforward, but many stumbled by not recognizing these classic Jura styles and then tried to shoehorn the wines into a region/style that simply wasn't logical. A lot of points could have been gained from simply describing what was in the glass even if the region was unknown, especially for parts b and c.

Question 3

Question 3—the trio of wines/styles from Sauternes, Bordeaux—was well-managed by most. The 2007 Château Rieussec should have been a banker, and it was for many. A few students even managed to get that the dry wine (wine 5) was also from Sauternes, even though legally, it cannot be labeled as such. Those who suggested Bordeaux for the overall region passed so long as they zoomed in on Sauternes for the sweet wines. However, the “commercial opportunities and challenges” section of the question was less well answered, with some candidates ignoring this part or offering superficial responses that were not specific to what was in the glass.

Question 4

The flight of four wines of varying sweetness and alcohol levels at the end of this paper was where many candidates came undone. It wasn't designed to throw students off, but it did. Given that the questions were nothing new or surprising, the stumbling block was straight-up identifications of regions, grapes, residual sugars, and alcohols. This type of question highlights that there is no substitute for breadth of experience.